

Malama ia Floral Design, LLC

In 2023, Tina Toro Evans was laid off from her job as assistant vice president at a bank. Her husband, Cameron, on active duty with the U.S. Air Force, was deployed overseas, and she had young children at home. Toro Evans had to decide quickly what the next chapter in her professional life would be. Fortunately, the bank offered her a severance package¹, and that bought her some time and funds to use if she wanted to launch her own business. Toro Evans thought about what she loved doing and what potential customers in the Tucson area might need, and she quickly settled on a floral business.

“My passion for design and floral arranging really started with my father—we loved working in the garden together,” Toro Evans said. “We had over 50 rose bushes, palm trees, and even banana trees in our garden.” Before her banking career, Toro Evans had worked in the floral department at a Seattle grocery store, where she learned the business side of flowers and floral arranging.

She knew there was a need for this service in the Tucson area. She’d heard many of her friends and neighbors in the community complain about the high cost of floral arrangements. So in 2024, Toro Evans launched a floral design business out of her home in Vail, Arizona, with a vision to “create beautiful, lasting floral arrangements that bring joy and meaning to every customer and occasion.” She chose the name Malama ia (mal-ah-mah ē), which means “to care for/of” in Hawaiian, in honor of her father’s love of flowers and her commitment to community.

Meeting Customer Needs



Figure 1. Toro Evans’s silk flower bouquets

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Like most florists, Toro Evans loves natural cut flowers, but she was concerned by the waste created by the floral industry, knowing that 40% of all harvested flowers like tulips and roses end up in the trash before even hitting store shelves (Waghmode et al. 2018). Instead, she decided to use silk flowers, which could be high quality without creating so much waste (Figure 1). She had even used them for her own wedding bouquet.

Toro Evans worried that some customers might push back against artificial flowers, but she found the opposite to be true. Her customers embraced her silk creations—she learned some were even allergic to real flowers—and Malama ia experienced an exponential

¹ A severance package is pay and benefits an employee may receive when they lose their job. The value of the severance package depends on a variety of factors including the type of business, the employee’s salary, and the length of their employment.



Figure 2. Tina and Cameron with a holiday floral arch

Source: © Tina Toro Evans

increase in sales in her first year.

Before long, Toro Evans’s customers wanted more than bouquets and centerpieces. They were also looking for convenient table, chair, and décor rental options for their events, which could simplify their planning and minimize stress.

“When you hear ‘I wish you could ... ’ or ‘would you be able to ... ’ from your customers, my first question to myself is ‘well, why not?’” Toro Evans said.

Her “why not?” approach led to additional types of floral arrangements, like large floral arches that serve as photo-friendly backgrounds at big events (Figure 2).

A Growing Business

By 2024, Toro Evans was providing silk flower arrangements and décor rentals for weddings, funerals, conferences, graduation parties, and other events. Her company delivered, set up, and took down all of the arrangements and provided personalized signage for each event.

“I take immense pride in customizing every detail of my clients orders. Whether they want a different type or color of flower, or a different floral filler and greenery, or even different sizing,” she said in an interview with Shoutout Arizona. “Any preference our clients have, we are always happy to say yes!” (Local Stories 2024)

One of her fears was growing too big and diversifying her offerings too quickly. Investing in inventory for rentals, including large numbers of tables and chairs, leasing a unit to store the rentals, and navigating the ever-changing preferences of a growing client base was challenging, especially with changing themes and aesthetics. She offered a 100% satisfaction guarantee—a promise that Malama ia will recreate any order that doesn’t satisfy the customer—which meant she had to stay ahead of every trend.

Toro Evans’s experience in banking, employee training and development, and leadership were invaluable when it came to honing her skills in customer service, relationship building, and business management, which she needed for her floral business. Her experience also gave her the confidence to make sound decisions.

One year in, Toro Evans is well on her way to achieving profitability and thinking about next steps, with a goal of someday becoming a nationally recognized floral design business.

Topic 1.4 Case

Tina Toro Evans was interviewed in 2025 by a College Board case author for this case study.

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